

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN MEXICO

Complete Community Opposition How-To

A practical manual for ejidos and comunidades, campesinos, Indigenous peoples, fishing communities, and citizens' groups facing a dam, a mine, a highway, a wind or solar mega-park, an industrial corridor, or a tourism development on land or water they depend on. Mexico is dangerous for land defenders — among the deadliest countries on earth for them — so this guide puts safety first throughout.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Hold onto one fact before anything else, because it's true and it's Mexican: **a community owned its land in common, guarded the assembly that spoke for it, used the courts built for exactly that — and beat a state-owned mega-dam that had loomed over their river for half a century.**

That's the record of **La Parota**. When the Federal Electricity Commission (CFE) moved to build a 900-megawatt dam on the **Río Papagayo** near Acapulco — a project that would have flooded some 17,000 hectares, displaced 25,000 people, and harmed 75,000 more downstream — the campesinos of the communal lands of Cacahuatpec didn't wait to be consulted. On 28 July 2003, villagers blocked the CFE's engineers from their land, and that same day formed the **Consejo de Ejidos y Comunidades Opositoras a la Presa La Parota (CECOP)**. Their decisive weapon was distinctly Mexican: because the land was collectively owned, the dam needed the consent of the community **assembly (asamblea)** — and when the CFE tried to manufacture that consent through rigged assemblies, CECOP took the matter to the **agrarian courts**, which **annulled the fraudulent assemblies**. Alongside that, an **amparo** — Mexico's constitutional injunction — froze the illegally granted environmental clearance and water concession. They held the line for twenty-three years. In July 2026, the federal government declared La Parota **cancelled for good**. The river still runs, and the communities still hold their land.

La Parota teaches the pattern, and it rests on two facts you must understand from the outset. First, roughly **half of all the land in Mexico is social property** — **ejidos** and **comunidades**, owned and governed collectively — and a project on that land needs the **asamblea's** consent, enforceable through specialised **agrarian courts**, which annulled the fraudulent assemblies the CFE tried to manufacture. Second, layered over that is the **amparo**, a fast and powerful constitutional suit that can **suspend** an act that violates your rights — as it froze La Parota's illegally granted clearance and water concession. Together, collective land and the amparo give Mexican communities two of the strongest tools any people anywhere hold against an unwanted project. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly, because the cost of this fight was terrible. CECOP endured internal splits, repression, and the jailing of leaders — and in 2025 its long-time spokesman, **Marco Antonio Suástegui**, was assassinated by a hired gunman in Acapulco, a year before the cancellation he had fought for. Mexico is one of the most dangerous countries in the world to defend land and water. That danger is not a reason to give up — La Parota shows what endurance wins — but it is the reason every step in this guide is built around protecting people.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A big project looks unstoppable, but it's a chain of approvals and dependencies, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A large Mexican project needs the **asamblea's consent** where it's on social property; it needs an environmental clearance (the **MIA**) from **SEMARNAT**; it needs land, water concessions, and financing; where Indigenous peoples are affected it needs **prior consultation**; and it can be frozen by an **amparo**. Every one of those is a link you can grab. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend a year on this, work out your real situation:

- **If the land is an ejido or comunidad, you have Mexico's strongest shield** — the asamblea's consent, enforced by the agrarian courts, the way La Parota was.
- **If a right is being violated — a clearance granted illegally, a consultation skipped — the amparo can freeze it fast.**
- **If the state itself is the developer and pushing hard, it's a long, dangerous war of endurance** — La Parota took twenty-three years and cost lives, so build for the long haul and put safety first.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **use the tools the law gives you** — the assembly, the agrarian courts, the amparo, prior consultation — and **run every front at once**: the documents, the assembly, the courts, the movement, the press. And a third, in Mexico: **protect your people at every step.**

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

Several bodies hold pieces of the decision. **SEMARNAT** (the environment ministry) grants the environmental clearance based on the **MIA** (*Manifestación de Impacto Ambiental*). **CONAGUA** grants water concessions. The **agrarian authorities and courts** govern social property and the validity of assemblies. State and municipal governments handle local permits and land-use. And where Indigenous or tribal peoples are affected, the state owes **prior consultation**. Know which body holds the decision you can contest, and aim there — but remember the asamblea's consent underlies it all on social property.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The assembly (on social property). A project on an ejido or comunidad needs the **asamblea's** agreement to use the land. *Your opening* — and it's the strongest one: guard the assembly. A consent obtained by fraud, pressure, or a rigged quorum can be annulled by the agrarian court, as at La Parota.

The environmental clearance (MIA). SEMARNAT reviews the MIA, with a public-consultation stage. *Your opening*: file objections and a **denuncia popular**; a clearance built on a defective MIA can be challenged.

Consultation (where Indigenous peoples are affected). *Your opening*: a consultation that wasn't free, prior, informed, and culturally appropriate is a violation you can take to court.

Construction. *Your opening*: works without valid permits or the asamblea's consent, or in breach of the clearance, can be frozen by an amparo.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who's behind it and who owns them** — a state company like the CFE, or a private consortium, which sets the political and reputational exposure. **What it still needs** — the *asamblea's* consent not obtained, the clearance or water concession not final or under challenge, financing not closed: whatever's missing is the soft spot. **Who's paying** — public money, and banks or international lenders with their own environmental and social standards.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. **SEMARNAT and PROFEPA** (the environmental enforcement agency) run and police the clearance and can be pressed. The **agrarian courts** (the *Tribunales Unitarios Agrarios*) rule on the validity of assemblies — the La Parota lever. The **federal courts** hear **amparos** and can suspend a violating act fast. The **National Human Rights Commission (CNDH)** takes rights complaints, including threats to defenders. And Mexico's **strong campesino and Indigenous movements, its environmental and human-rights organisations, and a brave press** are the forces that reach furthest — the combination that sustained La Parota for twenty-three years.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether the land is social property, whether a right was clearly violated, whether you can protect your people, and how set the state is on the project.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Guard / annul a rigged assembly (agrarian court)	30–55%	months–yr	low–mod	Fraudulent consent voided (La Parota)
Amparo (constitutional suspension)	30–55%	weeks–months	low–mod	A violating act frozen
Denuncia + objections on the MIA	15–35%	during review	low	Clearance conditioned or a redo
Prior-consultation challenge (Indigenous)	25–50%	1–3 yr	low–mod	Approval quashed for no real consultation
Movement + national/international press	25–50%	months–yr	low	Political cost; project reconsidered
Everything together (social property, world watching)	40–65%	1–5 yr	low–mod	Stopped, frozen, delayed, changed
Everything together (state-backed, no social-property shield)	20–40%	1–5 yr	low–mod	Delayed, conditioned, exposed

The levers that move the needle most are the **asamblea and the agrarian courts** (on social property) and the **amparo**, backed by consultation rights, the movement, and the press. La Parota shows the ceiling (a state mega-dam beaten) and the terrible floor (twenty-three years and a defender murdered). Honest wins include a frozen clearance, a voided assembly, delay, and exposure as much as a clean cancellation.

On cost and safety: guarding the assembly, documenting, and organising are cheap, and the amparo is a fast, powerful, relatively accessible constitutional tool. But this is deadly ground for defenders — document safely, protect the vulnerable, route risk through the courts and human-rights bodies, and never let the fight cost a life if it can be helped.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this assembly, this clearance, this right — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

- 1. What is it, and who's behind it?** Name the project, the company (state or private), and its financiers.
- 2. Where is it, and what does it touch?** Get the boundaries and lay them over social property (ejido/comunidad), Indigenous land, water, forest, protected areas. **Social property is your strongest shield**, so establishing that the land is an ejido or comunidad is your most important fact.
- 3. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline?** Is an assembly being called to approve land use? Is the MIA in public consultation? Has a clearance or concession been granted (opening the amparo window)? These openings are time-bound.
- 4. What does it still need that it lacks?** The asamblea's consent, a clearance, a water concession, financing. The missing piece is the soft spot.
- 5. Who else is affected, and who already opposes it?** The ejidatarios and comuneros, the affected villages, campesino and Indigenous organisations, human-rights groups. La Parota united communities across five municipalities.

What this looks like in real life. A community learns a dam or mine is planned on their communal land, and the CFE or a company starts calling assemblies to get "consent." The five questions yield: a state or private developer behind it; land that is social property (the shield); an assembly being engineered and an MIA pending; a project still needing the asamblea's real consent and its clearance; and a coalition of comuneros and organisations. That's the La Parota pattern — guard the assembly, take any fraud to the agrarian court, and be ready with an amparo.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can fight and one that can't is proof. Build it in three layers — safely.

Layer one: the paper trail. Get the documents the decision rests on — the MIA, the environmental clearance and its conditions, the water concession, the assembly records (the *actas*), the agrarian registry. Mexico's transparency law gives you access to public information, so demand what isn't public. Then read the MIA hard for flaws, and scrutinise every assembly for irregularities — a rigged quorum, absent comuneros, pressure, fraud — because that is where La Parota was won.

Layer two: the ground truth. Dated, located photographs and video of the site, the river, the land — baseline images before any damage most of all — and, carefully and with consent, the testimony of affected families. Protect anyone who could be endangered.

Layer three: the map of rights. Lay the project over the ejido/comunidad boundaries, Indigenous land, water, and protected areas, so each shield is visible. Walking into the agrarian court or a federal court with

the clearance, the assembly records, and that map is what makes them act.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The MIA, the clearance and conditions, the water concession** — from SEMARNAT and CONAGUA; force out the rest under the transparency law (8A).
- **The assembly records and the agrarian registry** — from the ejido/comunidad and the agrarian authorities.
- **Ownership and financing** — company records and lender documents.
- **The rights map** — the ejido/comunidad boundaries, Indigenous land, water, and protected areas, laid over the site.
- **Dated site evidence and consented testimony** — photographs marked with date and place, gathered so no one is put at risk.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; people give you power — and CECOP held a durable movement together for twenty-three years. Build your coalition in four moves — and safely.

Start with the assembly and a tight core. On social property, the *asamblea* is both the community's heart and a rights-holder in law. Build around it, with the families most affected and a few trusted organisers.

Guard the assembly above all. The single most important organising task is to keep your assembly clean and united — because a rigged assembly is how projects manufacture "consent." Know your quorum rules, record everything, and challenge any fraud immediately in the agrarian court.

Widen the circle. Pull in the neighbouring ejidos and comunidades that share the land or water, the campesino and Indigenous organisations, and human-rights groups. Hold meetings where people see the evidence and understand their rights.

Bring in the allies and lawyers — early, and build to last. Reach the campesino, Indigenous, and environmental organisations and the human-rights lawyers who know the agrarian courts and the *amparo*. These fights run for years and can turn deadly: build clear roles, a secure shared archive, a way to decide together, and a real plan for the physical, legal, and emotional risks. Take threats seriously, protect the vulnerable, and route danger through lawyers and human-rights bodies.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES, THE ASSEMBLY & THE AMPARO

Law is arguably Mexico's sharpest lever, because of the agrarian courts built for collective land and the *amparo* built to stop rights violations fast.

The Assembly and the Agrarian Courts

On social property, the **asamblea's consent** is the gateway to the land, and the **agrarian courts** (the *Tribunales Unitarios Agrarios*) exist to police it. A consent obtained by fraud, a rigged quorum, or pressure can be **annulled** — exactly what CECOP won at La Parota, where the agrarian court nullified the assemblies the CFE relied on. Guard your assembly, document any irregularity, and take it to the agrarian court.

The Amparo — the Constitutional Freeze

The **amparo** is Mexico's great constitutional remedy: a suit that a violation of your rights be stopped, and — crucially — it can grant a **suspension** that freezes the challenged act while the case runs. An amparo froze La Parota's illegally granted environmental clearance and water concession. Use it against a clearance granted without the *asamblea's* consent, a consultation skipped, or any act that violates your rights — and seek the suspension to stop the works now.

Consultation and the Environmental Route

Where **Indigenous or tribal peoples** are affected, the state owes a **free, prior, and informed consultation**; one that wasn't genuine is a violation you can take to court. And on the environmental side, file objections and a **denuncia popular** with **PROFEPA** and SEMARNAT against a defective MIA or a project operating in breach of its clearance.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: the agrarian courts and the amparo are real and have beaten mega-projects, but the fight is slow, the state is often the developer, and — above all — Mexico is deadly for defenders. So use the strong tools — the assembly, the agrarian court, the amparo, consultation — but pair them with the movement and the press, put safety first at every step, and count a frozen clearance, a voided assembly, delay, and exposure as wins alongside a clean cancellation.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

A document becomes a case for the agrarian court. Not "the project is bad" but *"the assembly the CFE relies on lacked a quorum and was obtained by fraud — it's void, and so is the consent."*

A right becomes an amparo. *"The clearance was granted without our assembly's consent and without consulting us — it violates our rights, and we seek its suspension."*

The land becomes a shield. *"This is our communal land; it can't be used without the *asamblea's* real agreement."*

The harm becomes a national story. *"The river and the land our families have always lived from — for a dam we never agreed to."*

Match it to the venue: the assembly fraud to the agrarian court; the rights violation to the amparo; the MIA's flaws to PROFEPA and SEMARNAT; the human story to the press.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Mexico, national and international attention is a real lever — and, on deadly ground, a shield: a watched community and a known defender are harder to disappear. La Parota became a national and international cause, and that reach protected its people as much as it pressured the state.

Lead with people and place, not procedure. Not "the MIA was procedurally deficient" but "the river, the land, the life our community has always known — for a dam we never agreed to." Use your strongest material: dated photographs, the map of the project over your land, the assembly's stand, and — carefully, with consent — human testimony.

Work several audiences at once. Local and national press build political pressure; campesino, Indigenous, and human-rights networks amplify; international media and human-rights bodies reach the financiers and watch over your people. Make it easy: captioned photos, accurate summaries, a map, strong voices.

Two hard rules, and they matter more here than almost anywhere. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can be turned against you. And protect people — weigh every publication, shield the vulnerable, and let the community decide what is said and by whom.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them factual and calm; keep copies; and protect anyone at risk.

8A — Transparency request (to SEMARNAT / CONAGUA).

Subject: Solicitud de información — [proyecto].

"Under the transparency law, we, residents of [place], request the MIA, the environmental clearance and its conditions, and the water concession for [project] at [location]. [Contact.]"

8B — Objection / denuncia popular on the MIA.

Subject: Observaciones y denuncia popular — [proyecto].

"We, residents of [place], object to the environmental clearance of [project]: [the MIA understates these impacts / ignores our water and land]. We file this denuncia popular and ask that the clearance be refused or a proper assessment required. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — Challenging a rigged assembly (to the agrarian court, via a lawyer).

Subject: Nulidad de asamblea — [ejido/comunidad].

"We seek the annulment of the assembly of [date] relied on for [project], on the grounds that [it lacked a quorum / was obtained by fraud or pressure / excluded comuneros]. [Attach the acta and evidence.]"

8D — Filing an amparo (to a lawyer).

Subject: Amparo y suspensión — [proyecto].

"We instruct you to file an amparo against [the clearance / the concession / the lack of consultation] for [project], and to seek the suspension of the act, on the grounds that it violates our rights [specifics]. Please act promptly. [Attach the act and our evidence.]"

8E — Asserting the right to consultation (Indigenous communities).

Subject: Derecho a la consulta — [proyecto] en [lugar].

"As an Indigenous community affected by [project], we are entitled to a free, prior, and informed consultation, which has not genuinely taken place. We call for the process to be halted until it is properly conducted. [Contact.]"

8F — To a human-rights body / the CNDH.

Subject: Protección y queja — defensores de [lugar].

"We report threats against our community and its defenders in connection with [project], and ask for protective measures and an investigation. [Contact and details.]"

8G — Letter to the press.

Subject: [Community] moves to protect [river / land / water] from [project].

"For generations the people of [place] have lived from [the river / the land] at [location]. Now [project] threatens to destroy it, and we never agreed to it. We can provide photographs, documents, a map and — carefully — interviews. [Contact.]"

8H — Rallying the community (safely).

Subject: We can stop this — here's how.

"[Project] threatens [our river / land / water]. At La Parota, communities held their communal land, guarded their assembly, and beat a state mega-dam over twenty-three years. With our assembly, the agrarian courts, the amparo, and the movement behind us, we have a real chance. Please join us — carefully, protecting one another. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. **Nail down the project and its footprint, and confirm whether the land is social property.** An ejido or comunidad is your strongest shield.
2. **Guard your assembly.** Know your quorum, record everything, and challenge any rigged assembly in the agrarian court at once (8C).
3. **Get the MIA and the concession (8A), read them for flaws, and file a denuncia (8B).**
4. **Photograph everything, with dates and places — safely.**
5. **Get a lawyer and be ready to file an amparo with a suspension (8D).** It can freeze a violating act fast.
6. **Go public and find your movement (8G) — carefully.** Attention pressures the state and protects your people.

Even lean, those six use your rights, protect the assembly, build the record, and put a legal freeze and a movement within reach.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Mexico's tools are real, but the field is often tilted, and the danger is real, so plan for both.

When the state is the developer. As with the CFE at La Parota, the state may be the one pushing the project and manufacturing consent. Don't fold: guard the assembly, use the agrarian courts and the amparo, keep the movement and national attention alive, and make the state's coercion a public cost.

When assemblies are rigged. This is the classic Mexican tilt — a fake or pressured assembly to fabricate consent. The answer is vigilance and the agrarian court: a fraudulent assembly can be annulled.

When defenders are threatened. Mexico is among the deadliest countries for land defenders, and La Parota lost Marco Antonio Suástegui. Take every threat seriously, seek protective measures from human-rights bodies, work through lawyers, protect the vulnerable, and use national and international attention as a shield.

What still works, and it's a lot. Collective land and the *asamblea* give real power; the agrarian courts annul fraudulent consent; the *amparo* freezes violations fast; consultation rights are enforceable; and a determined, watched movement can outlast even the state — La Parota did, for twenty-three years.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Mexico has serious, documented problems with the capture of permits and land by powerful interests, so this matters.

How to spot it. Assemblies bought or rigged; clearances granted over the technical evidence; an MIA written for the proponent; consultation staged to exclude the affected; benefits to co-opted leaders while the community carries the harm; opaque public spending.

Who's supposed to guard against it. **PROFEPA** polices environmental compliance; the **Auditoría Superior de la Federación** examines public money; the **Fiscalía** and anti-corruption bodies investigate graft; the **agrarian and federal courts** can void tainted assemblies and acts; and the **CNDH** takes rights and defender complaints. And Mexico's **investigative press** has repeatedly exposed captured projects — at real risk to journalists.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — how the assembly was rigged, who benefits, what the law required — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the proper bodies and trusted journalists rather than making public accusations you can't back — doubly important on deadly ground. Protect insiders and witnesses. Pair the exposure with the legal challenge and the public campaign.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The documents build your proof; confirming the land and the rights aims it; guarding the assembly holds the ground; the agrarian courts and the *amparo* press the case; the media raises the cost and protects your people. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall.

Early on (weeks 1–8): nail down the project, its footprint, and whether the land is social property; guard the assembly and record everything; get the MIA and the concession; photograph the baseline safely; get a lawyer and prepare an *amparo*; build your core — protecting your people.

In the thick of it (months–years): annul any rigged assembly in the agrarian court; file *amparos* with suspensions against illegal clearances or skipped consultation; press the consultation and environmental routes; deepen the coalition; open the media front at home and abroad.

The long haul (years): carry the cases through the courts; keep the assembly clean, the movement alive, and national and international attention on your people; hold the line for a frozen clearance, a voided assembly, delay, or an outright cancellation — as La Parota, after twenty-three years, finally won.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Mexico can be done — communities held their communal land, guarded their assembly, and beat a state mega-dam after twenty-three years — and the same story is honest about the price: decades of struggle and the murder of a defender. Hold both. Mexico's tools are real and, in parts, unusually strong: collective land and the *asamblea*, whose consent a project needs; agrarian courts that annul fraudulent assemblies; the *amparo*, which freezes a violating act fast; and enforceable consultation rights. And the constraints are grave: the state is often the developer, assemblies are rigged, and Mexico is among the deadliest places on earth to defend land.

Here's the discipline that wins. Confirm the land is social property, and guard your assembly above all — a rigged assembly is how projects steal consent, and the agrarian court can void it. Get the MIA and the concession, and be ready to file an *amparo* with a suspension to freeze an illegal clearance now. Assert your consultation rights. Carry the story to the nation and the world, and protect your people at every step. Brace for a long, dangerous fight, and count a frozen clearance, a voided assembly, delay, and exposure as wins alongside a clean cancellation. That's what La Parota did — collective land, the courts, the *amparo*, and a movement that refused to quit, for twenty-three years. So can you.